

ESMA Market Report

# Crowdfunding in the EU 2025



*ESMA Market Report on Crowdfunding in the EU 2025*

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# Editorial

Dear Reader –

This is ESMA's second annual market report on the EU crowdfunding market, based on data we receive from NCAs under the European Crowdfunding Service Providers for Business Regulation, which came into effect in November 2021.

Crowdfunding is a form of alternative finance that typically involves small investments from many people (or a 'crowd') through digital platforms. Crowdfunding services providers offer a publicly accessible digital space where investors can explore and invest in various projects. This type of funding is important for SMEs, which often struggle to secure traditional bank financing. Crowdfunding serves as an important source of alternative finance and has the potential to support the development of the Savings and Investments Union. ESMA is tasked with fostering a harmonised regulatory environment across the EU to enhance the efficiency of crowdfunding, with a strong focus on enhancing investor protection.

This second market report expands the data coverage and analysis from the first edition, helping to enhance transparency, monitor risks and build investor confidence in crowdfunding platforms. In line with our mandate, ESMA will continue to produce annual market reports to monitor the evolution of the European crowdfunding market. As the market matures and more data are gathered, we envisage continuing to extend the analysis in future reports to identify market trends and any related potential risks.

Additionally, we have recently carried out survey-based analysis of the impact of artificial intelligence (AI) on financial sector entities. We set out results for a sample of crowdfunding service providers, which give insight into current and planned adoption of AI tools in the crowdfunding sector.

# Executive Summary

Across the EU, 181 crowdfunding service providers raised over EUR 4bn of crowdfunding in 2024. In total, 21 Member States hosted at least one active provider.<sup>1</sup>

Over half (58%) of crowdfunding in 2024 was in loan-based projects, followed by debt-based projects (23%) and equity-based (12%). This distribution of funding by instrument type was similar to the previous year, as was the distribution of investors by type, with a large majority (88%) classified as retail investors.

The top five countries in terms of capital raised were France (EUR 1.45bn), the Netherlands (EUR 1bn), Spain (EUR 0.45bn) Italy (EUR 0.29bn) and Lithuania (EUR 0.28bn). Together, providers in these countries raised over 80% of the total across the EU (EUR 4.25bn). While most funding via providers in France was debt-based, the leading type of crowdfunding in the other largest markets was loan-based.

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<sup>1</sup> In 21 EEA countries, at least one provider with 'authorised' status that had begun raising capital by the end of 2024 (AT, BE, CY, CZ, DE, DK, EE, ES, FI, FR, IE, IT, LT, LV, MT, NL, PL, PT, RO, SE, SK). The remaining 9 EEA countries reported no such providers.

# Market monitoring

# Crowdfunding in the EU – market overview

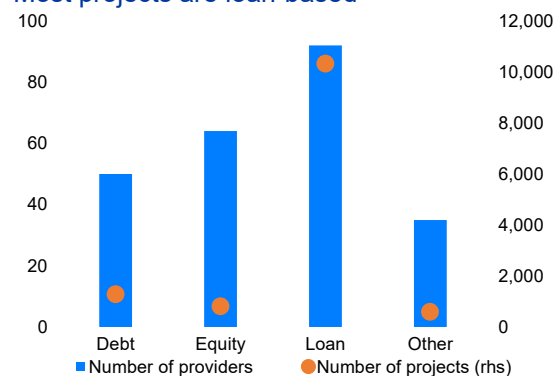
In total, 181 crowdfunding service providers raised a total of **EUR 4.25bn** in the EU in 2024, across 21 Member States.<sup>2</sup>

## Funding models

Crowdfunding can take the form of loans, or transferable debt or equity securities.<sup>3</sup> Among the 181 reported providers, 137 offered a single type of funding model, with the remainder offering two or more types.<sup>4</sup> In total, 92 of the providers offered loan-based crowdfunding services, 64 offered equity-based crowdfunding and 50 debt-based funding (Chart 1).<sup>5</sup> Around 58% of funding raised was in loan-based projects, followed by debt-based projects (23%) and equity-based (12%).<sup>6</sup> These shares are broadly in line with those from the statistics for the crowdfunding market in 2023 (Chart 5).<sup>7</sup>

Chart 1

Providers by funding type  
Most projects are loan-based



Note: Number of EU crowdfunding service providers and number of projects (rhs), by type of funding, 2024. "Other" includes admitted instruments for crowdfunding purposes.

Sources: Data reported by NCAs, ESMA

<sup>2</sup> The analysis in this Market Report is based on data reported by NCAs. In total, 21 NCAs reported having authorised at least one provider that was active by the end of 2024, while the remaining 9 NCAs provided null returns (i.e. confirmed they had not authorised any active providers during the relevant period). According to the register of crowdfunding service providers that ESMA maintains under ECSPR, 229 providers had 'authorised' status by the end of 2024. The register includes providers that had not raised any funds by that time, however, and are therefore not included in the analysis in this report.

<sup>3</sup> Certain types of crowdfunding such as donation-based and rewards-based crowdfunding are outside the scope of this report and of ECSPR, which focus solely on investment-based and lending-based crowdfunding to business.

<sup>4</sup> According to the data, four providers each offered three types of funding model (debt-based, equity-based and loan-based), while 34 providers each offered two types of funding model.

<sup>5</sup> Debt-based crowdfunding differs from loan-based crowdfunding in that only the former involves a

transferable security. Other funding types include 'admitted instruments for crowdfunding purposes', defined under ECSPR as private company shares not subject to restrictions that would effectively prevent them from being transferred.

<sup>6</sup> Across projects, 46% raised less than EUR 1mn. Among these smaller projects, a far greater share of money raised was via loan-based funding than across all projects (91% vs 58%). A possible explanation is that loan-based crowdfunding may be easier to establish than securitised crowdfunding, and hence especially popular for smaller projects. A lower share of money raised via smaller projects was raised via debt-based funding than across all projects (4% vs 24%) and equity-based (3% vs 12%).

<sup>7</sup> Due to the limited data coverage for 2023, year-on-year trends in this Report should be interpreted with caution. Additionally, as 2023 was the first year of application of ECSPR, a relatively high share of projects may not have completed fundraising by year-end, which may explain why the average amounts raised per project were far higher in this year's Report than in the previous edition.

## Projects funded

Crowdfunding platforms facilitate the matching of prospective investors or lenders with businesses seeking funding, which tend to be start-ups and small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs). In contrast to banking, crowdfunding directly links investors and those seeking funding.

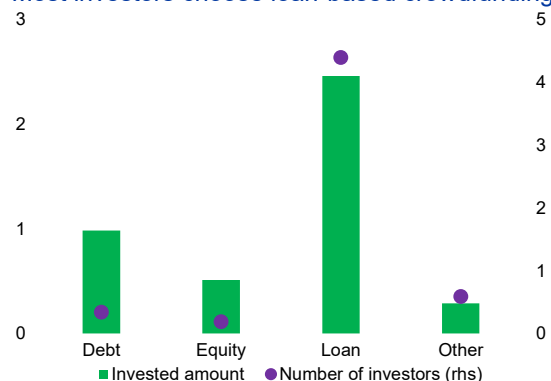
Loan-based crowdfunding projects were by far the most popular and numerous, with over 10 000 such projects offered in 2024, in which over 5.5 million investors participated (Charts 1, 2). The average amount raised per loan-based project was around EUR 240 000, much less than the corresponding figures for debt-based projects (EUR 770 000) and equity-based projects (EUR 640 000).

As in the previous year, the leading economic sector as a destination for crowdfunding finance in 2024 was professional, scientific and technical services. The sector saw EUR 1.35bn of investment raised, almost a third of the total of EUR 4.25bn (Chart 4). The category includes a range of activities, including management consultancy, legal services, advertising and scientific research and development. Projects involving construction – including civil engineering as well as construction of buildings – raised the second-highest amount of funding, at EUR 1.04bn, a quarter of the total. In terms of investor numbers, however, the leading sector for crowdfunding projects was real estate, with 1.45mn investors participating. This high level of investor participation may reflect limited opportunities for retail investing in real estate projects via traditional means in some countries.<sup>8</sup>

Chart 2

### Investing by funding type

Most investors choose loan-based crowdfunding



Note: Invested amount, in EUR mn, and number of investors (rhs), by type of funding, 2024. "Other" includes admitted instruments for crowdfunding purposes.

Sources: Data reported by NCAs, ESMA.

## Investor base

A large majority (88%) of investors in crowdfunding projects were classified as retail investors (Chart 2). A further 11% were classified as 'sophisticated' investors by providers under ECSPR, while 1% were 'professional' investors under the MiFID framework. These figures are similar to those for the previous year (Chart 6).

Across the whole market, the average amount invested by each retail investor was around EUR 660, while for sophisticated investors and professional investors the respective figures were EUR 2 660 and EUR 1 510. Sophisticated and professional investors would be expected to invest greater amounts than retail investors, on average, as they typically have more financial wealth.

<sup>8</sup> In some markets such as France however, real estate was a key sector for crowdfunding despite the existence

of alternative collective investment vehicles providing real estate exposure.



## Geographical profile

France had the highest number of providers (50), followed by Italy (27) and Spain (25) (Chart 7). The top five countries in terms of capital raised were France (EUR 1.45bn), the Netherlands (EUR 1bn), Spain (EUR 0.45bn), Italy (EUR 0.29bn) and Lithuania (EUR 0.28bn). Together, providers in these countries raised over 80% of the total across the EU (EUR 4.25bn).

Among these large markets, France was the only to have debt-based crowdfunding as the leading instrument type (50% of funding raised), with loan-based crowdfunding 23% of the total (Chart 9). In contrast, loan-based crowdfunding was the most common type in the Netherlands (81%), Spain (60%), Italy (50%) and Lithuania (96%).

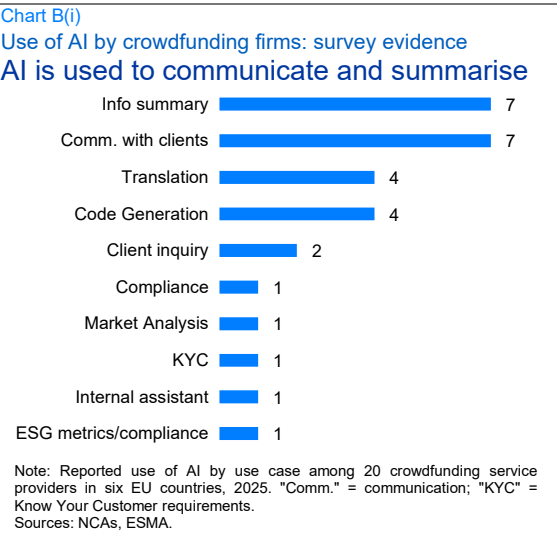
Lithuanian providers had the most projects (2 640) (Chart 7). The level of development of the crowdfunding market in the country reflects the fact that Lithuania has had national legislation in place since 2017 for the sector. Likewise, France and the Netherlands, which between them hosted around half the providers in the EU, have had national regimes established since 2014 and 2020 respectively.

Cross-border activity, characterised as the share of investments raised by platforms in a country by residents of other countries, varied greatly across Member States (Chart 10). Providers in several countries (Poland, Portugal, Romania, Slovakia) catered only to domestic investors, while in Malta (100%), Estonia (77%) and Latvia (47%), large shares of client numbers were resident in other countries. In the largest markets, however, only a small proportion of funding was through non-resident investors. On average, across all providers, 8% of funding was raised cross-border,

most which was from EEA-based investors.<sup>9</sup>

## Technological trends

ESMA monitors how market participants use innovative technologies. Given recent advances in artificial intelligence (AI), ESMA has assessed the technology’s impact on firms across the financial sector, including a sample of crowdfunding service providers (Box 1, Chart B(i)).



<sup>9</sup> Around 5.8% of total funding was cross-border from other EU/EEA countries. Only 2.2% of total funding came from residents of third countries.

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**Box 1****Use of AI by EU crowdfunding service providers: Evidence from ESMA survey**

In summer 2025, ESMA carried out an EU-wide survey to assess the use of AI in securities markets. Within the crowdfunding sector, responses were received from 20 providers from six countries (France, Portugal, Ireland, Spain, Belgium, Malta). Among those providers that reported their size, almost all were micro (11) or small enterprises (4), with one medium-sized company.<sup>10</sup>

10 providers reported having AI use cases in development, while six already had AI use cases in production. Eight expected to crease their AI investments over the next 2–3 years, primarily driven by expected cost reductions, particularly from Generative AI (GenAI).

AI was mainly applied to operational and back-office tasks, including summarising information translation, and code generation. Some firms also reported using AI in client communication and query handling. The most frequently used technologies were Generative AI, Natural Language Processing (NLP), and Agentic AI.<sup>11</sup>

Overall, AI applications used were reported as low-autonomy, meaning there is always human oversight or approval of AI-driven decisions. 11 respondents reported using externally developed models, either off-the-shelf or internally customised, while only one firm reported having developed an AI model fully in-house. There was strong reliance on third-party providers, particularly for cloud services.

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<sup>10</sup> Based on Eurostat definitions, micro-companies have <10 employees, small 10-49, medium 50-249, and large 250+.

<sup>11</sup> For more information on these concepts, see e.g. Bagattini, Benetti and Guagliano (2023), *ESMA TRV*

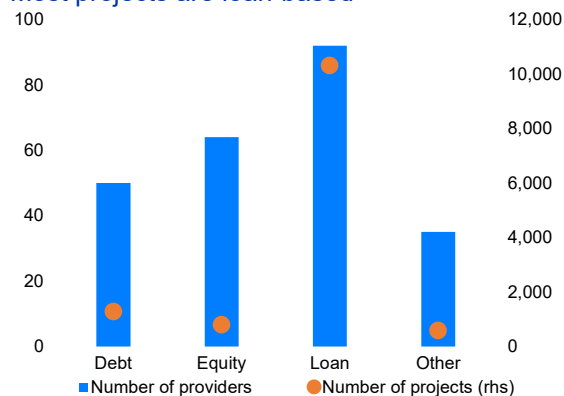
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# Annex

# Statistical annex

Chart 1

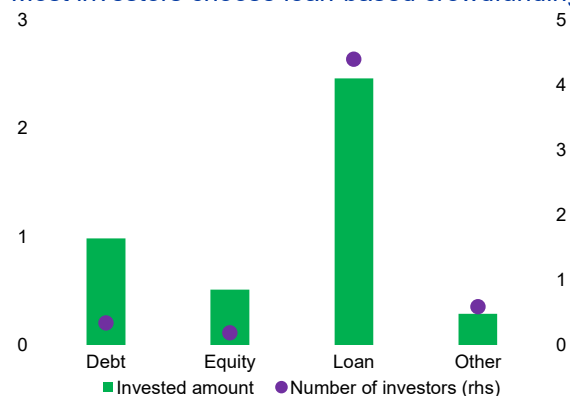
Providers by funding type  
Most projects are loan-based



Note: Number of EU crowdfunding service providers and number of projects (rhs), by type of funding, 2024. "Other" includes admitted instruments for crowdfunding purposes.  
Sources: Data reported by NCAs, ESMA

Chart 2

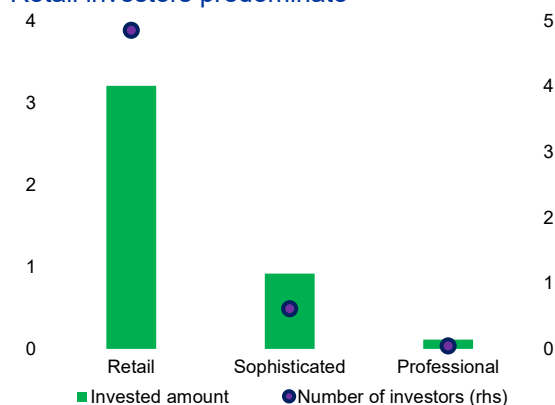
Investing by funding type  
Most investors choose loan-based crowdfunding



Note: Invested amount, in EUR mn, and number of investors (rhs), by type of funding, 2024. "Other" includes admitted instruments for crowdfunding purposes.  
Sources: Data reported by NCAs, ESMA

Chart 3

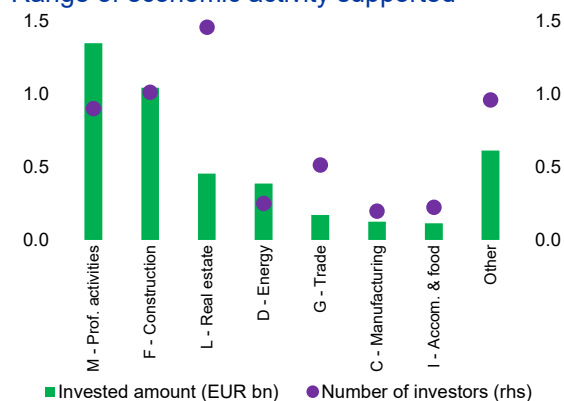
Investors by type  
Retail investors predominate



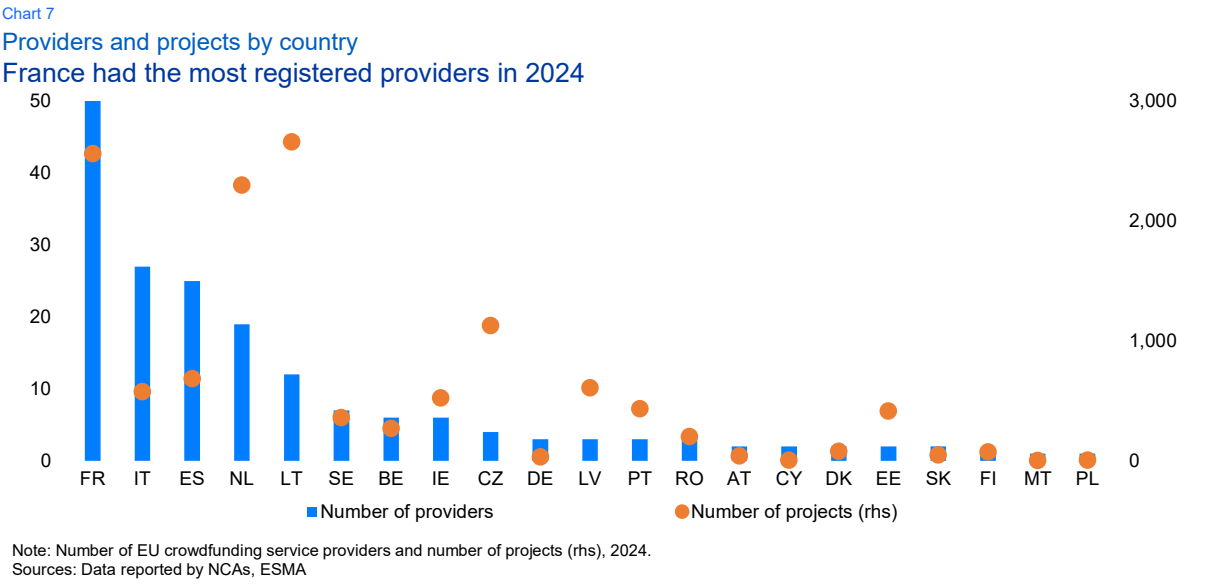
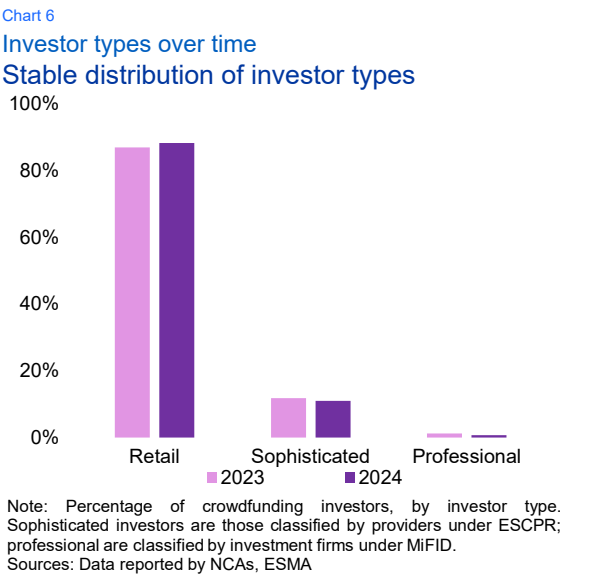
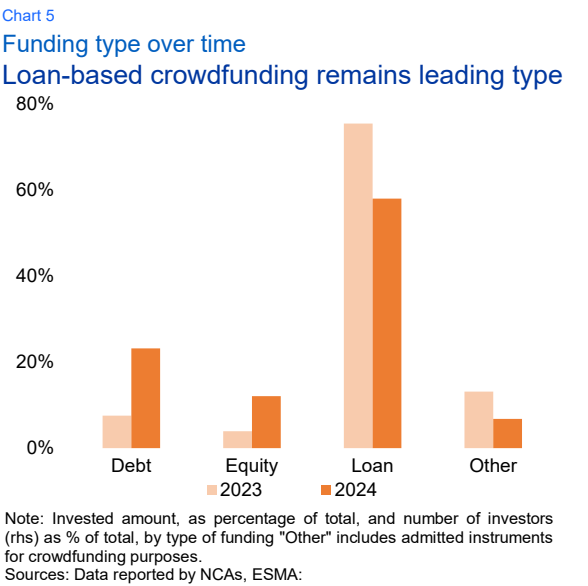
Note: Note: Invested amount, in EUR bn, and number of investors, mn (rhs), by investor type, 2024. Sophisticated investors are those classified by providers under ESCPR; professional are classified by investment firms under MiFID. Sources: Data reported by NCAs, ESMA.

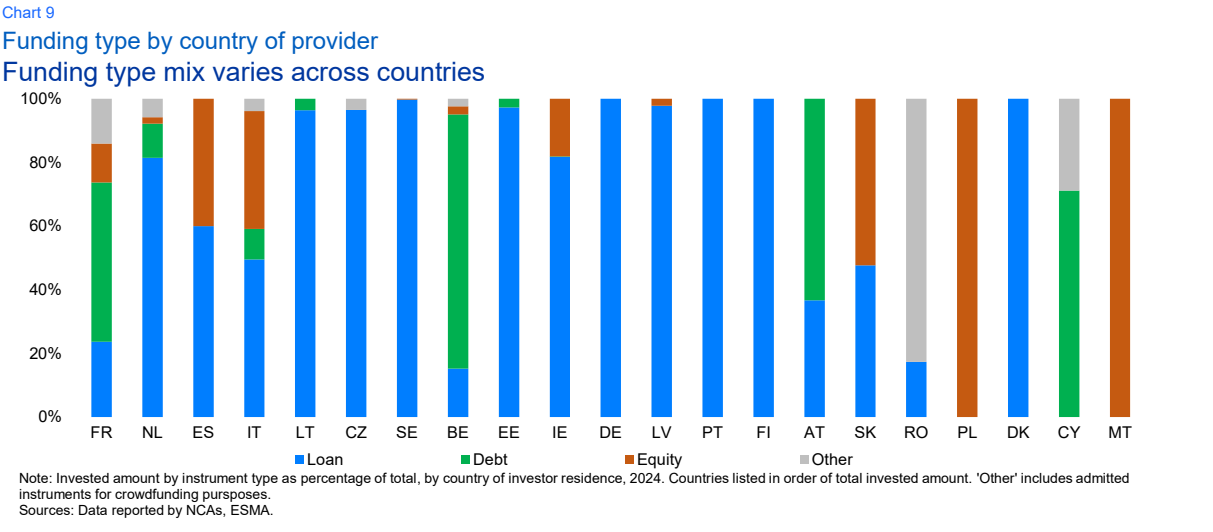
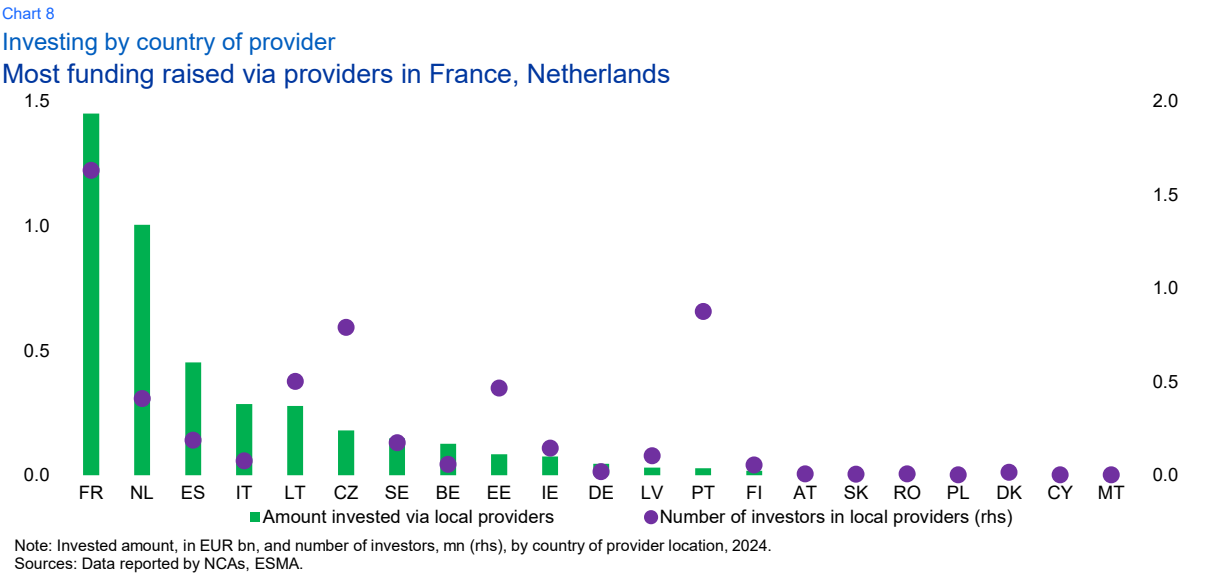
Chart 4

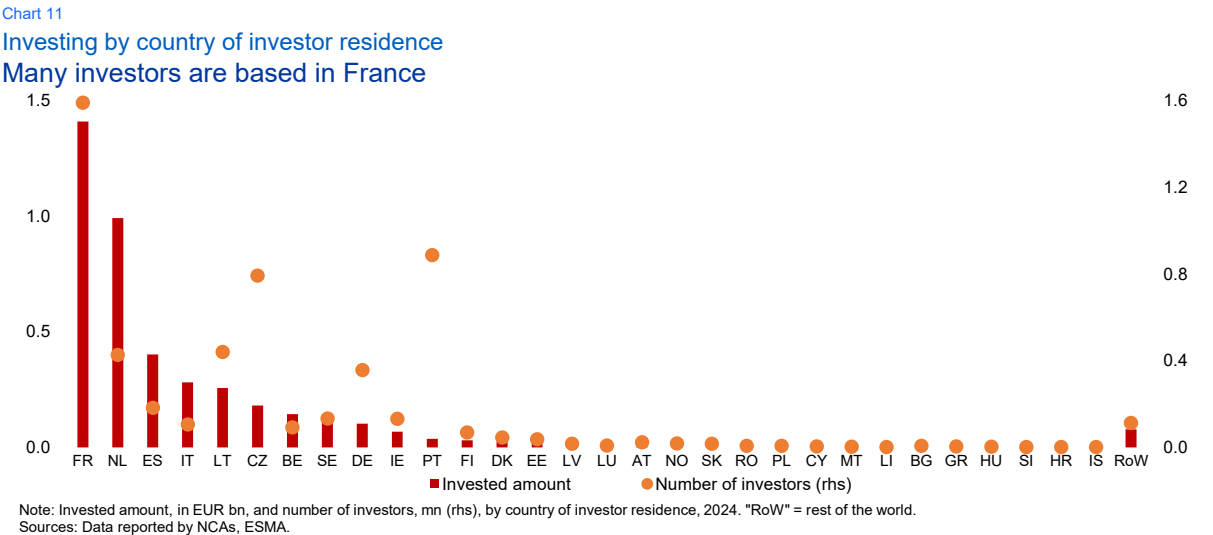
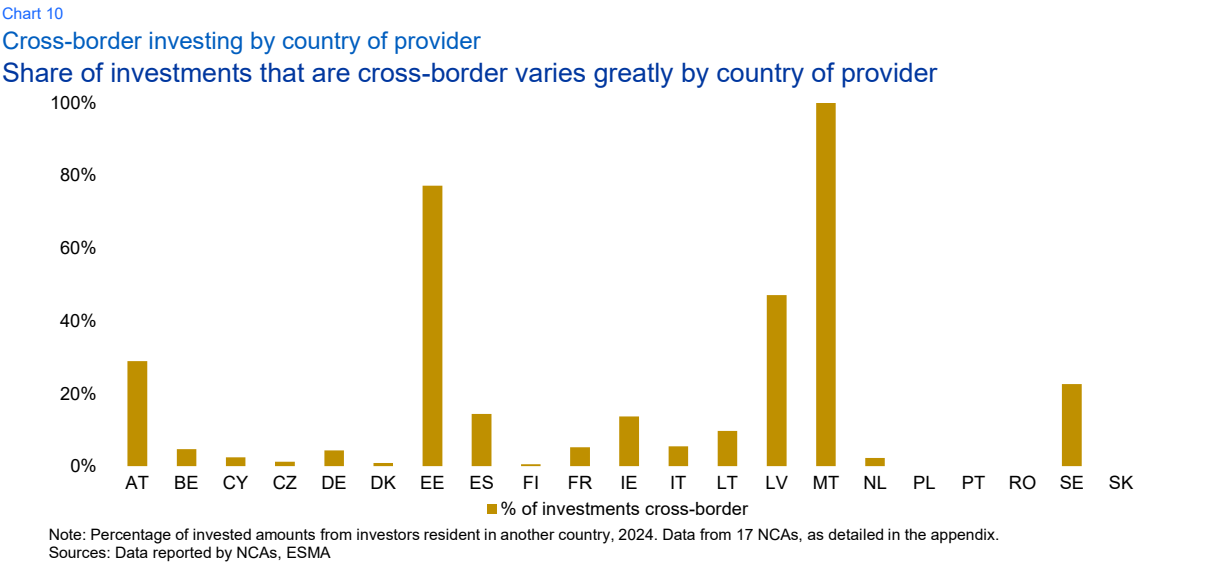
Projects by economic sector  
Range of economic activity supported



Note: Invested amounts, in EUR bn and number of investors, mn (rhs) by economic sector, 2024. "Prof. activities" = professional, scientific and technical activities; "Accom." = accommodation. Sector codes are NACE Level 1, revision 2, per Regulation (EC) 1893/2006, which gives definitions. Sources: Data reported by NCAs, ESMA.







# Data used

In line with ESMA's mandate under Article 16.2 ECSP to produce an annual market report, EU NCAs provided ESMA with anonymised data relating to crowdfunding platforms registered in their jurisdictions for the 2024 reporting period.

The NCAs, in turn, obtained this information from authorised crowdfunding service providers in their jurisdictions who are required to submit it annually and on a confidential basis for each project funded through their platforms.

The fields reported in the data include:

- the project owner and the amount raised;
- the instrument issued (whether investment- or lending-based); and
- aggregated information about the investors and invested amount broken down by fiscal residency of

the investors, distinguishing between sophisticated and non-sophisticated investors.

ESMA developed a standardised data collection template for NCAs to use in gathering this information and provided technical support, including the sharing of ESMA software scripts for automated data quality checks. The data collected by NCAs through this exercise were used to compile this report, along with some other sources referenced in footnotes and the main text.

The analysis in this report is based on data returns from NCAs across the EEA, of which 21 had at least one provider with 'authorised' status that had begun raising capital by the end of 2024 (AT, BE, CY, CZ, DE, DK, EE, ES, FI, FR, IE, IT, LT, LV, MT, NL, PL, PT, RO, SE, SK) and 9 provided null data returns (BG, GR, HR, HU, IS, LI, LU, NO, SI).



# Legislative framework

By 2020, several Member States had developed their own bespoke regimes for crowdfunding, which created fragmentation and hindered the cross-border provision of these services. This regulatory divergence discouraged cross-border investments, limiting the potential for a unified EU crowdfunding market.

Regulation (EU) 2020/1503 on European Crowdfunding Service Providers for Business (ECSPR) established uniform rules across the EU for investment-based and lending-based crowdfunding services used for business financing. Offers exceeding EUR 5 mn, calculated over a period of 12 months, are excluded from the scope of ECSPR.

ECSPR sets organisational, operational, and supervisory requirements for crowdfunding service providers, along with specific provisions for investor protection, including marketing rules, disclosure obligations, and conflict of interest safeguards.

To enhance investor protection, ECSPR assigns ESMA various policy and market analysis roles. In line with this mandate, ESMA has developed technical standards and Q&As<sup>12</sup> and maintains a register of all crowdfunding service providers<sup>13</sup>. It also has a coordination role with National Competent Authorities (NCAs), including in relation to the publication of national regulations applicable to marketing communications.<sup>14</sup>

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<sup>12</sup> ESMA published the relevant [technical standards](#) in 2021. Article 14 ECSPR mandates ESMA to maintain a register of providers.

<sup>13</sup> See <https://registers.esma.europa.eu/publication/>

<sup>14</sup> Articles 28 and 29 ECSPR.

# List of abbreviations

|                                                   |                                                                                    |
|---------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ECSPR                                             | European Crowdfunding Service Providers Regulation (Regulation (EU) No 1503/2020)) |
| EEA                                               | European Economic Area                                                             |
| ESMA                                              | European Securities and Markets Authority                                          |
| EU                                                | European Union                                                                     |
| MS                                                | Member State                                                                       |
| MiFID                                             | Markets in Financial Instruments Directive                                         |
| NCA                                               | National Competent Authority                                                       |
| SME                                               | Small or Medium-sized Enterprise                                                   |
| Countries abbreviated according to ISO standards  |                                                                                    |
| Currencies abbreviated according to ISO standards |                                                                                    |

